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Sam Kininger

Sam Kininger grew up in Oriskany, NY and excelled in classical and jazz saxophone as a high school student. He is a Berklee College alumnus and has become one of the most recognized soul/jazz artists in the business. Sam has toured extensively with Soulive and Lettuce, and currently performs with the Sam Kininger Band.

Sam was interviewed in Clinton, NY on May 27, 2011 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm really pleased to have Sam Kininger here, and, we go way back.

SK: Yes, we do. I'm very pleased to be here, by the way, it's good to see you.

MR: I'm glad you're back in the area. You know, when you used to come to my house, I have to tell you that all conversation stopped in the house, no one could watch television. My family used to say, "He's got a big sound."

SK: Man, wow, great.

MR: It was great.

SK: Well it's really your fault because — um not your fault but — like you know I was, basically as you know, before I was a classical musician, like [plays]. You know, like the Glazunov Concerto. And I don't think there's anything wrong with that. But then you introduced me to Cannonball Adderley, and that changed my whole world around. It really did.

MR: Well it changed mine too. You know I think there was something about him that is still sort of indescribable. But it's something to aspire to.

SK: Definitely. Still.

MR: We'll talk more about that. I'm wondering if you felt like a big fish in a small pond growing up in Oriskany? For those people who are watching this, Oriskany is like a little adjoining town to Utica.

SK: Yeah. It's not even a town it's a village. But yeah, I mean in the town itself there really wasn't that much going on. I mean we had the chorus and the band, and I had a great teacher, Frank Galime, he was the person who really kept me going for a long time, and then he introduced me to you, and also Jack Adams from Holland Patent. So simultaneously I had outside instruction, and that allowed me to go on to around to New York State NYSSMA competitions and I got involved, in chorus, I was singing in All-State Chorus and playing in All-State bands. So I had an opportunity to grow a little bit outside of the surroundings of Oriskany.

MR: Was your whole childhood in Oriskany?

SK: Yeah. From birth. I was born in Utica, but, you know, I lived in Oriskany. So I graduated high school from there.

MR: Was there a point, I mean I'm sure we knew each other at that point, but did you decide, let's say, I want to be a full time musician. When did that happen for you?

SK: That happened, wow, I mean I didn't know what it would be, or even what instrument at the time, but I knew it was something that I wanted to do, to perform, and it just was one of the few things, I think, that felt right. You know in high school I was in the chorus, and like all the other kids I did track and football, at the same time studying Glazunov concertos and Haydn sonatas. So my focus definitely broke away from sports. I was like I'm not going to be a football player you know. So this is something I seemed to be sort of good at.

MR: Was the sax your first instrument?

SK: Yes, yeah, and still it's like my main instrument. I mean I'd like to say I can play other things but this is number one.

MR: The process of learning, and the discipline of playing classical music, did it end up helping you later on?

SK: Oh, yeah, tremendously, with technique. Just getting around the horn. You know, playing thousands of arpeggios and scales, over and over and over and over again definitely gives you muscle memory and dexterity, and articulation.

MR: So yeah, when it came time to go to somewhere else, was Berklee your first choice?

SK: Yeah. Well I applied to Manhattan and Eastman, but Berklee was the main one, yeah. And actually, even as for my audition I played a classical piece.

MR: At Berklee.

SK: Yeah and actually, I don't know if you remember it, I still have it, I have an audition tape that we did at your house.

MR: Oh my.

SK: And they had these requirements for the Manhattan School, and one was "play a jazz tune." And I think — what did we play — [plays "Blue Monk"]. That one?

MR: "Blue Monk."

SK: Yes, we played "Blue Monk," and I forget the other one.

MR: We might have played a bossa or something?

SK: Yes. I have the tapes.

MR: Yeah? Cool.

SK: And you know all these requirements were there, but somehow I got a scholarship at Berklee for classical music.

MR: I didn't even know they did classical.

SK: Yeah, they have a symphonic — they call it symphonic orchestra, and which has everything, strings, brass, saxophones, everything. But it was definitely a transition because I was checking everything else out too at the same time I was checking out Cannonball, Coltrane, Parker, and all the other people who eventually — I guess you could say I'm a late bloomer when it comes to like jazz. I didn't really focus on it until later on, like maybe a senior in high school and in college —where a lot of the kids I met grew up and they already had it.

MR: Yeah. They might have come from one of those high schools that had an amazing program and a lot more bodies. Do you call yourself — let's say you meet somebody that you don't know, and they say what do you do. What's your answer?

SK: Musician.

MR: You don't call yourself a jazz musician?

SK: I describe myself as musician. Yeah. And then the other question is well what kind, what do you play? And then still I'll have a hard time describing it. Yeah definitely I think my influence has been, all kinds comes together in different ways.

MR: Was the — I don't know if I could call it a decision — but you sort of entered this subfield of funk, instrumental funk. Was that — what made you go in that direction as opposed to becoming like more of a bebop player?

SK: Well we kind of touched on it before we started, I am more of a percussive type, a rhythmic player I guess you could say. So I gravitated to people like Maceo Parker and things like that. And I was like, oh, this feels right. And at the same time I could throw in what little jazz stuff that I did have, and incorporate it into the distilling process of you know, jazz is definitely a more complicated situation, where in the jam band world type thing it's maybe a modal or like a one chord thing. But you can expound on things. Does that answer your question?

MR: It does. And it makes me think of well, one of my questions I wanted to ask you. The term jam band, I think I've probably heard that, one of the first times I heard it they were referring to the band Pfish.

SK: Um hum. Oh yeah.

MR: Of course The Grateful Dead too, but it became more of an accepted term, a jam band. But what does it really mean?

SK: I guess it means there's a lot of jamming going on. You know? I mean from a jazz perspective you have a melody and then maybe that circles around a few times and then everybody sort of jams I guess. I don't know how else to put it, really, because really that's what it is. But I guess I like to, like I have my own band situation and I would like to maybe it's not really jamming, but it's not jazz either. It's sort of in between. We're

trying to keep it less jammy for hours, and keep it just some more grounded in a way. I guess it's like funk music, funk music I'd say.

MR: Is it safe to say that most jam bands don't play as many chords?

SK: Oh definitely. Yes.

MR: Yes. And they also don't play swing grooves.

SK: Ut uh.

MR: As often.

SK: Naaaaa.

MR: If at all?

SK: Naaaa. I mean I've been to a million festivals throughout the U.S. now and it kind of has the same vibe to it, a lot of it. I'm not trying to bad — but yeah, yeah. It's sort of a one chord situation.

MR: But that in effect, I think has its own bit of difficulty to it.

SK: Yes it does.

MR: What the heck do you do for twelve minutes on A minor.

SK: That's what I was about to say. It allows you to become a little bit more creative in your mind, so you can't do the same things over and over and over again. And you also learn how to build a solo as opposed to just start somewhere, take the solo to a different place and bring it down a little bit, and so then of course bring it up there. And then everybody in the band goes up to that point. So there's that aspect of it that's — and that's not easy to do either. You have to have good chemistry with the people you're playing with, as well as chemistry from the crowd as well. So I'm involved with that vibe situation.

MR: Good point.

SK: Yeah.

MR: It's a neat feeling I think to sort of be in control if your band is with you.

SK: Yeah, otherwise it doesn't work. You're like ahh, ahh. You're out there and you're kind of like, okay.

MR: Or the opposite, if you want to start your solo down and they're like.

SK: Exactly. Yeah, I've like, many, many times, if you've ever been to my shows, I'm always — my drummer Nikki, she's my favorite drummer, but she's always like —

MR: I think I saw you at the Electric Company with her.

SK: Oh yeah, yeah. Yeah, she's the drummer for Beyonce Knowles.

MR: Yeah. She likes to whack that snare drum.

SK: Yes she does. And every other drum. But yeah this is definitely a dynamics issue. Being able to communicate. I guess that would be the same for every situation band-wise.

MR: I was looking at one of theYouTube clips of you last night and it was with Soulive I think, and I think the tune was "Right On"?

SK: "Right On."

MR: Okay. So down below there's all these comments people make.

SK: Um hum.

MR: And the guy, someone wrote "what is Sam playing at 4:07?" The guy had timed the thing, and I said well I'm going to listen to this. And sure enough, when it got to 4:07 you played something that was out of the chord so to speak.

SK: Oh okay.

MR: So shall we say "outside."

SK: Right. Yeah I do that a lot, yeah.

MR: So how do I ask this? Do you have things in your head that you know you can go to?

SK: Sort of, yeah. Well I guess it's like finding your way home, is the best way I can figure of explaining. Like if you're in one chord like F say for example, you know a lot of people, you know you can go a half step above F, a half step below F, while you're soloing [scats] you know and just resolve it. So maybe that's what he's hearing? It sounds different when you're in that jam situation, you know what I mean? Because it's not like a jazz progression but I'm playing over that change. In my mind I'm playing kind of over a different change and kind of creating other chords, but then it all comes back to one, if that makes sense.

MR: Sure. Does it — because theoretically those could be called "wrong notes."

SK: Yeah.

MR: So how do you make them right?

SK: You're only a half step away, right, from the right note? Someone said that to me once.

MR: Yeah. Okay.

SK: But I play a lot chromatically. I play, obviously rhythmic things and then it's just fun to go outside of just playing and it definitely stimulates your mind and it forces you to think while you're playing too, and it's like how do I get back to this place? You know?

MR: No, that's very well said. Because you probably would never end your solo being a half step away from where you should be.

SK: [scats] No, you've got to get back to F. I do a lot of that though I guess. I don't know what the word is for it, but yeah.

MR: Playing outside, coming back.

SK: You ever check out Kenny Garrett?

MR: Um hum.

SK: He does, a lot of his phrasing is like that. So check him out. He definitely influenced my style of playing.

MR: So after you got out of Berklee, how did you sort of get into the music scene, or try to — what was the first step in trying to make a living at it.

SK: I was sort of in it already while I was at Berklee. Around ’94 I started playing with a big band, well it was many other things, but there was a jazz big band at Berklee and it was called Kendrick Oliver New Life Jazz Orchestra.

MR: Kembrick Oliver?

SK: Kendrink Oliver. They’re still around. Check them out. Kendrick Oliver New Life Jazz Orchestra. We started there, I was one of the original guys, and our first thing was like let’s play Count Basie charts, let’s play Duke Ellington charts, just to get the tradition. And then a faculty started writing charts for us, and then we started playing outside of the school, we started going to libraries and things around Boston. So that was how I started getting into Boston, in that big band. And what else. I played in this band called Fat Bag and we were more of like an R&B/funk band that played around Boston too. And then we started going to New York City and venturing out, and then the people that were in that band I still play with today, like in Soulive and in Lettuce, like Eric Krasno, and so we’ve known each other for almost twenty years now. So I’ve kind of had the same core of people that I’ve been playing with, you know. Then I have my own band which is a little bit, outside, and I met up with them years later.

MR: Are your members spread out geographically?

SK: Not too far. It’s mostly the northeast. New York City, Boston. Our bass player is in California.

MR: That’s pretty spread out if you’re trying to line up a gig you know. Yeah, I want to talk about that more, like what it’s like to try to lead a band. But so I guess it’s sort of like the typical musician’s story, you need to get exposed, you need to meet people.

SK: Definitely. Also to find people to come to play with. Also all throughout that I was playing several other types of gigs like wedding gigs and, you know, working at this place called Wally’s in Boston, it was like a weekly gig for me, Wally’s Café. And that was sort of a school outside of the school. That’s where everyone got — you know you hear stories about the jazz clubs where Charlie Parker got a cymbal thrown at him. It’s that type of place where you kind of honed your chops and if you couldn’t play the band would suck. Like I would go in and try and play “Night in Tunisia” or some type of — and I thought I could play over it. But then all of a sudden one by one they left. If you couldn’t hack it, that’s how you get your chops I guess.

MR: Because the rhythm section was older players?

SK: They were older players, familiar with every standard in the Real Book and had been playing it for the millionth time. So here I come, young Sam, thinking I could, it just happened to everybody too. And then you had to be able to cut it, basically. So that was Wally’s experience. It’s like real life experience, getting punched in the face. And then

you're like okay, I'd better go practice. I'd better go play this again if I ever set foot in there again. And then, you know, I just kept on playing in the Boston scene a lot.

MR: If you were going to tell a student, in relation to that experience, "You better know the tune." What do you need to know about the tune?

SK: You need to know the form, especially that. Because a lot of people in the beginning would forget A-A-B-A. You think it's the simplest thing in the world, but you go back to A after the first B, done. Make sure you know the form. Play over it. Solo over it as many times as you can and listen to it over and over and over again, and hear where the tune's going to go. Don't go back to the top. It's like you think it'd be easy, but in the heat of the moment when you're like maybe stressed and worried and things like that, you forget and then whoops.

MR: It's interesting, on some of those songs like "So What" or something, it's A-A-B-A, except because the chords are so simple you can mess it up.

SK: Yeah, yeah, yeah exactly. Or "Impressions," it's the same thing.

MR: Right. Right. So you got this, you've been in and out of Soulive and now this band, the band Lettuce is part of Soulive?

SK: Some of them, yeah.

MR: They share members sort of?

SK: Yeah. Like Eric Krasno, the guitar player is in both. Neil Evans is the keyboardist in Soulive, and is now a member of Lettuce. The only person that isn't there is Alan the drummer. So it's myself, Eric Krasno, Neil Evans and the other members who are rhythm guitar player Adam Smirnoff, and the bass player from California, his name is Eric Coomes.

MR: So who books these bands? You have an agency?

SK: Yeah. It used to be called Valor Records out of New York, but now it's called the Royal Family Productions.

MR: I did see that on your record.

SK: And that incorporates a lot of our family that I was talking about for the past twenty years. You have my band, you have Soulive, everyone has their kind of like solo projects that they're involved in. And then we all come together and do Lettuce records.

MR: Nice. Is it a hard life?

SK: Yeah. It is. I mean you're not going to make a million dollars. You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah. It's like an oxymoron, rich jazz musician.

SK: Exactly.

MR: I think people don't realize that.

SK: Yeah.

MR: They probably see you up on stage.

SK: I know. Like all these people and you think it's — but man a lot of it throughout the years, you know, packed in the van with the whole band, and then carrying stuff in and out. People don't see all the sharing hotel rooms and sleeping on the floor in sleeping bags and just scraping by just to make even you know. And then if there was any left and we got lucky we got paid, most of the time. But it's one of those, you know, you can stick it out or try something else I guess.

MR: The people that don't stick it out and try something else, do you think that they have more options? Like well I was good at accounting. Or I could be an accountant as well as a musician so, I don't know if I really asked that question but —

SK: Like having more options is definitely a better thing. I would say even as a musician going to school for maybe not performance but adding something to it like production engineering so that you have another outlet as far as being in the scene but so that you don't have to be an accountant or something else. You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah. I do know what you mean. And do you think that Berklee or whatever post-high school education you had, you had the talent first. Right? They can't teach you the talent.

SK: You know what, yeah. Not really, yeah.

MR: Did they help you though, I mean how much?

SK: Oh yeah. Yeah I had quite a bit of instruction there as well, this guy, his name is Bill Pierce and he played with — I don't know if you've heard of him —

MR: Yeah. I know Javon Jackson mentioned him.

SK: Oh yeah, yeah. Javon Jackson. Yeah he's insane. He can play just as well. Was he here?

MR: He was here, yeah.

SK: But I definitely had good private instruction there, and Andy McGhee was another one, at Berklee. He was one of those old school, kick you in the tail type where if you weren't prepared he'd tell you to leave and come back when you've got the whole chapter done. But yeah, I got a lot of instruction from other students as well. Like my friends that came from those arts high schools and then introduced me to a lot of music I'd never heard before. So there was a lot of hanging out and like listening to a million John Coltrane albums just to know them. And then we had the ensemble rooms where everyone jams, jam sessions but like in jazz style. But we would sit for hours and hours and hours in this room, probably an ensemble room like this, one of those soundproof rooms and everyone would go around in a circle. It was fun. It would be like Friday nights when everyone else was going to the bars, we'd go, "Let's have a jam session." And you'd go into Berklee and find one of the rooms and just sit around until 5:00 in the morning. I learned a lot just from my friends.

MR: I want to take you back to the thing you said about being packed into a van and sleeping on the floor. I mean that sounds like my rock & roll days. I mean some things never change, right?

SK: Yeah, that's how the band Lettuce started too. It's like the word "lettuce" was like let us use your house, or like let us use your food, let us use your instruments. Because we were like let us sleep on your floor. So really yes, we played these crazy gigs, and then afterwards you'd think like where is the hotel but you're like okay, I'll get that corner over there. It happens. It's all part of the struggle.

MR: Now when you go to play a gig, like you said you went to New Orleans, I assume that —

SK: Yeah. It's a bed. There's always a bed now. That's a good thing. That's always a plus. But even with my band, when we first started getting around I mean there was four of us and my manager, we'd all share one room. It would be two people in a bed and the manager on the floor. But after a while you get tired, definitely. When you're younger you know like it's fun just to be able to play out.

MR: Yeah. There's sort of the adventure factor.

SK: Exactly, yeah.

MR: "This is a good exposure gig for you."

SK: Yeah. How many times did I hear that.

MR: Really. I have to laugh because Carmen Caramanica around here said, "You know you can't eat exposure."

SK: Yeah. I know. You can't eat exposure.

MR: What about — things have changed very quickly now for how you record, how your records get out there, how you promote yourself. Is the Internet and YouTube and iTunes, do you think that's been mostly a good thing?

SK: I think so. For musicians like myself I think it has been. Because even fifteen years ago, or ten, when we first started recording the Soulive albums it had to be in a big studio, you know, like in New York or whatever, they had to be in this huge studio with a big console and everything. We don't do anything like that now. We don't need it. But like we recorded an album in Alan's basement and yeah, he's good at what he does and he's got good equipment. He uses ProTools. But that part of it is definitely — it saves a lot of money.

MR: And what about a record label? Do you guys do your own?

SK: It's our own record label now. It's not like a SONY record deal, which we had, we had the Blue Note recording deal which was cool but getting it self-produced is definitely more advantageous to us, and like the iTunes situation is definitely good. We sold a lot of records, with Lettuce especially.

MR: Cool. But if I went to a Barnes & Noble in Syracuse, I probably wouldn't find Lettuce records, or would I?

SK: You'd find Soulive ones. But people don't even go out that much and buy CDs anywhere either.

MR: Right. They download individual tunes or whatever. And you mentioned you had been to Japan to play? What's that like?

SK: It's amazing. Yeah. That's when you feel like sort of a rock star in the, I guess, jam band world. Over there they appreciate it so much differently than here. Like over here it's appreciated but I don't know how to explain it. Yeah, we're like superstars over there as far as like the appreciation of the music. They understand what's all going on, where in some cases over here people are just kind of listening. It's always quiet. Like we played at the Blue Note in Tokyo and it's sort of a jazz club setting, but during the song — dead silence by the crowd there. Like they were focused in and watching everything that goes on. And in the end, in the uproar, you know, a huge note, whatever, and then you have that kind of stuff and then they get down and they're waiting. They're just waiting for the next — and it's intense.

MR: It must have been a little disconcerting at first.

SK: It was at first. But then you realize they're really into it. They're really into the music. And it's definitely a different experience at first. I was like woah, another level of appreciation I guess.

MR: Would you or any of the guys in your circle ever consider moving there?

SK: I have. I have, yeah. I have friends that are over there that I went to Berklee with, and they have done that and they're earning a good living too. Like for example my friend Anthony Wonsey is a jazz pianist. He played with Kenny Garrett and he still does the jazz circuit and does all the clubs and stuff. But he lives in Tokyo. And while he's there he has a kind of like a hotel sort of situation, but he does that and he plays jazz gigs and he teaches there. And I have a few other friends. But not to mention just my friends who are Japanese. They were in Berklee and then moved back home.

MR: Well did you ever see those old *Down Beat* where — well they probably still do — they do blindfold tests?

SK: Uh no.

MR: It's like you're sitting listening and the guy plays a record and you have to tell what him what it is.

SK: Oh no. But — are you going to do it?

MR: I am going to do it. But you know what?

[loud audio interlude]

SK: Oh, a reaction. What I did when I heard that the first time. Roy McCurdy, right? And was it Sam Jones? Sam Jones?

MR: I think it was.

SK: Wow.

MR: And Nat and like, that's like one of the greatest moments.

SK: That was an easy one.

MR: Yeah. That's the only one I picked out. Because you know I wouldn't do that good on it. But I know what I know.

SK: What song was it?

MR: That was "The Sticks" I think.

SK: "The Sticks" okay. Amazing.

MR: If you had students, like what would you tell them to listen to?

SK: Cannonball I think. Well yeah, depending on what style they're trying to get into. If they're trying to play and trying to get some groove stuff and funk, obviously Maceo Parker. That would be one. And listen to like Herbie Hancock records for like funk. I can't remember, I'm spacing on the name, uh the saxophone player for Herbie.

MR: Recent?

SK: No from like the "Head Hunters."

MR: Oh yeah, I know who you mean. Now I won't be able to think of it either. Bennie Maupin?

SK: Yes. Bennie Maupin. Eddie Harris. Some good like groove kind of stuff, John Coltrane, not for that but, yeah. I would say Maceo, listen to Kenny Garrett. If you're a saxophone player listen to Kenny Garrett.

MR: Do you have a fairly extensive CD collection?

SK: Yeah, they're all in my iPod right now. But yeah, I have somewhere around nine thousand songs in my iPod, varying from Jimi Hendrix to Michael Jackson to Cannonball to Mozart. So it's an all-around situation.

MR: So does Sam Kininger practice?

SK: Yeah — uh not as much as Sam Kininger should. He practices a lot on the gigs. Yeah, that's something I should definitely do a little more of.

MR: I would think that most of the stuff you do it's just as importance that you just have your endurance, you know. Because I know that as I have become more of a piano player that my embouchure wears out in a hurry.

SK: In jazz it still does too, yeah, it definitely happens, where like halfway through the gig, if I haven't — even for like a week or something like that. You know I'll put a new reed on, you know and then in the middle of the gig I'm taking shorter solos — "Why don't you take this one?" You know? But you have to stay in better condition.

MR: What would you, if you went home this afternoon and did a practice session, what would you practice?

SK: Long tones. Because intonation is huge. You know I would try and practice intonation, yeah. Because I have a problem with the upper register and I always have, being sharp. So that's what I would do. I would just practice tone. I wouldn't get all crazy with it I would just try and do slow tunes. Simple. [long tone] Just to make sure that it's the tone that you want also too. And then the range of the horn, obviously you go from top to bottom.

MR: If a sax player watches this later on, they might want to know, "What's he playing? "What's he playing?" Now you told me this horn was handed to you?

SK: Oh yeah. It's a bronze Yanigasawa. Yeah the guy from the factory, I was in the store playing different horns and I just happened to like this one. And you remember, I don't know if you remember the old Yanigasawa I had, I played a Yanigasawa all throughout high school and so I've always loved the horn. I've played Yamahas and Selmers and I've just always like the feel of the horn, it's like a heavy horn, it's got a good tone to it, buzz to it. But yeah, a Yanigasawa. And I always like the fact that it's got the space off the King, the old King that Cannonball used to play. So it's got that look to it also.

MR: There's something to be said.

SK: Yeah. It has a good buzz to it, like most horns don't have. I don't know, I just like the tone of them.

MR: What about your mouthpiece?

SK: The mouthpiece is a Meyer, and old New York Meyer, hard rubber. Actually that's a complete lie. The one that I have on right now is not. I've been testing out, did you ever hear of Jody Jazz? I have a friend who works for them and he sent me a bunch of mouthpieces to check out so I'm kind of checking out Jody Jazz's mouthpieces, but for twenty years or so I've played the Meyer. And that's what Cannonball played also as well. Right? Didn't he play a Meyer?

MR: You know I'm not sure.

SK: An old New York Meyer, because they made them out of hard rubber then. So I'm kind of checking out new mouthpieces from Jody Jazz.

MR: But you were never one of those people who, from my memory, that you agonized over your equipment.

SK: Yeah I kind of stay with the same thing, forever, really, and see I mean I've stayed with Rovner ligatures, it's kind of a newer model that they've come out with. Reeds I changed. I get a different reed, every box. I still have a hard time finding the right one. For instance these are Vandoren Java 2-1/2's but I've even tried using tenors. Jeff Coffin is the saxophone player with Dave Mathews right now? And I had asked him, because I went to

a show one time, and I said, "What are you playing now, for your alto?" And he goes 3-1/2 Java tenors. I'm like what? So I started doing that, and I got used to it for a while, but I gravitated down. But it's the one thing I would change the most is reeds.

MR: You've played with Dave Mathews.

SK: Uh huh.

MR: Was that fun?

SK: Great, yeah. It was amazing. And I was good friends. Well you know our relationship with them started with Soulive. We went on tour opening up for them, like we did this southern tour and then I became friends with LeRoi, the saxophone player who passed away, and so we kind of just had a relationship with them. Whenever they would come through I would sit in and also now that Jeff Coffin is in the band, who I've been friends with, so if they're ever around like in Albany or like that, we go check them out. It's usually the same tunes. Like, [sings] "Hey what'd you say" that tune.

MR: Oh right.

SK: So they always have me play that one.

MR: Is their music, it seems like the horn part and the violin part were fairly arranged. I mean they had worked it out beforehand.

SK: Yeah. And a lot of it's pretty, I wouldn't say simple, but it's yeah, it's definitely a good arrangement. That sound, which is strange too, the sound of the violin with the saxophone too kind of gives Dave Mathews that unique sound of his band.

MR: Yeah. I bet you have to pay attention to stay in tune with the violin player.

SK: Yeah. Well they all have those really nice in-ear monitors that are all set up so you don't really have to — like you can hear Dave Mathews talk like from the other side of the stage. That's how sensitive they are. And everyone's pretty much in tune.

MR: I mentioned, before we started we were talking about playing into microphones, clip on microphones and all that. How do you feel about that?

SK: I don't like clip on microphones too much. They just don't allow you to be as expressive. Because if you have like a mic you can pull back from it and control your volume and where if you're clipped on you can do that but you have to turn your stuff up and down. But I don't know, that's why I have all these scratches here because I'm always like — and I get yelled at a lot by it too, because they'll be too loud and the soundman has to turn me down and then I can't hear myself so I go even farther into the microphone and it feeds back. But that's the battle over my saxophone and microphones.

MR: Do you ever get into verbal arguments with sound people?

SK: Oh yeah. They get mad. They definitely, after a while, you don't piss off the sound guy or the monitor guy especially, if there is one. Because he could make or break your sound easily.

MR: Especially if you're a warm-up act. I know it used to happen to us. Why should they make you sound good? And it's not like you have enough money to throw them a few bucks either, you know?

SK: I know. Why give them a hard time. Actually it doesn't work either.

MR: Has traveling gotten somewhat better for you?

SK: Ut uh.

MR: I mean you have to fly to most of your gigs, don't you?

SK: Oh yeah. I usually fly out of Syracuse and get a connecting flight out of Syracuse usually and go out to California and New Orleans.

MR: You are able to take your horn on the plane?

SK: Um hum. I travel light too. Like it's just this and a duffle bag usually, and like a backpack. Or you know some of the guys have big huge suitcases, and it just takes up too much space.

MR: Yeah. Well it's a good thing you stuck with the alto.

SK: Yeah, yeah.

MR: Rather than a horn that you'd have an issue with. Did you ever mess with the soprano or be tempted to?

SK: I did, a little bit. And tenor too. I just really want to get a tenor soon. But I did like both and you know what's funny? Whenever I pick up a tenor I immediately want to play jazz. I start playing [scats] but when I'm on the alto I'm like [scats] so it's like two different instruments actually.

MR: Did you notice when you started transitioning into the funk world, especially with guitar player based bands, that you had to play in funkier keys?

SK: Yeah, for the most part, yeah.

MR: Of course Soulive is not a guitar — well

SK: They are. I mean they started out as like an organ trio situation, like we listened to old Wes Montgomery type things, like and George Benson style things, or who else, Lou Donaldson type. It was definitely an organ trio you know. Let's say Lettuce is like equally guitar and horn with the emphasis on the guitar and the horns.

MR: What do you, are you a goal-oriented person?

SK: Yeah, I am.

MR: What are your goals right now.

SK: My immediate goals is to record my next album, which I'm in the process of doing with my band who is Amy Bowles, Aaron Bellamy, the band you saw in Utica basically. I think they were all there.

MR: Yeah, I think so.

SK: My original band. We're planning on recording a new album, and then hopefully, I've never taken my band to Japan yet so that's a goal.

MR: After that you sort of deal with what happens to you.

SK: Exactly.

MR: Do you think you have — I know your wife works in Rome. Are you thinking about having a family or anything like that?

SK: Oh yeah, yeah. I mean I have a family already.

MR: Oh.

SK: So I definitely switched gears I guess you could say, over the past few years, where I still go out but it's not like the grind where I might be playing every weekend and every other night. It was that way for years. I'm kind of like focused on my family and then I would go to gigs that I would say are more beneficial for me to take.

MR: Yeah. I mean do you have a set figure in mind if someone calls you and says okay come down to New Orleans and be here for three days, and they say, and here's what we can pay you. Do you have a set figure?

SK: Yeah.

MR: Or say forget it.

SK: Yeah, yeah. I do. And that varies. That could vary. But yeah I don't go for less than a certain amount I guess. Is that what you're saying?

MR: Sure. Yeah. I mean it's good to have that sort of in place so that you don't have to think too hard about it on the phone with someone.

SK: Definitely. Uh, that sounds all right. Let me think about it. So yeah.

MR: Rewinding way back, I remember your mother being very supportive of you.

SK: Oh yeah.

MR: She seemed to really be behind you.

SK: Yeah, and as far as practicing and all that, and I mean we went to shows and I went to see Ray Charles and a lot of the shows that came to Utica she bought me records, like Lester Young records and John Coltrane records, which I didn't check out at first. You know I'd put it on and I'd be like well it's all right. But then later on I'd be like listening to it intently for hours and hours. She definitely was a big influence on my musical world.

MR: That's nice. Who is your — I don't know if this would be specific names — who is your competition these days, in the funk world?

SK: I don't know.

MR: Well is there a lot of competition for the kind of work that you get?

SK: Not really. And it's not like I'm just saying, like as far as my band is concerned it's more of a progressive sounding situation. Like you've heard it, it's just a lot of fast paced and high energy situations. Not that there isn't anyone else, I'm just saying that we seem to

stick out a little more than the other bands. Not in a better or worse way but like, it's kind of unique I guess. But there are, I mean there's plenty of instrumental bands, funk bands and party bands.

MR: Does your music get much radio play that you're aware of?

SK: A lot of college radio play, yeah. Like sometimes I'll actually hear Soulive on NPR. But I know the college radio stations just pump it on, not so much on regular stations.

MR: Okay, here's a hard questions, and nobody's ever been prepared to answer it, but what's the worst gig you ever played?

SK: Oh I could tell you.

MR: Can you?

SK: Yes. And actually no, we didn't even play it. That's how bad it was.

MR: Okay.

SK: There was this place, and I'm trying to think if there was a worse one. But there's this place in Massachusetts and I can't even remember the town, but the place was called Club Ice. And this was when I was in the band Fat Bag. And we walked in, and we were almost about to load on the stage and the owner of the place came up to us and was like, "What kind of music do you guys play?" And I'm like, you know, "R&B, pop, funk, and stuff like that." And he goes, "That ain't going to fly here." And so we picked up our stuff and left.

MR: Really.

SK: And it was one of those situations where we were about to play. I guess that was like a scary situation I guess. And our manager booked us at that place. So what else. Yeah I guess that's the first one that popped into my head, and actually we didn't even play the gig.

MR: It could have been worse if you did.

SK: It could have been worse, yeah, that is a hard one, yeah.

MR: Yeah. We tend to not want to think about those things. How about the best thing you've ever done? I mean is it possible to highlight a few?

SK: Well you mean — just recently one of the greatest, yeah, we did the jam cruise which was last year, and I got to play with Maceo Parker, Fred Wesley and Pee Wee Ellis, on stage, right next to me. If you go, there's pictures on Facebook and stuff, but what an honor that was, to be side by side with Pee Wee and like I said Maceo and Fred Wesley, was crazy. And we just got to do that again in New Orleans as well. Alfred Ellis, what a great guy he is, and he taught us a lot too. Me and Ryan Zorcas got to hang out with him a lot and Pee Wee taught us arrangements for us for these jazz round tunes that he wrote himself, like in "I Feel Good" and stuff that he actually wrote. That was, playing that gig was like, wow, definitely one of the highlights.

MR: You know it's hard to put into words the way those guys play those horn parts. There's something about it that's just so cool.

SK: Maceo alone, Jeez. When you've seen him live, it's like when you just played Cannonball, it goes right to your bones, it just goes right in there. I don't know how to explain it, but just to be around him was quite an experience.

MR: If you could — well you had the experience — I was thinking if you could go back in time and see or hear somebody, where would you go.

SK: Where would I go?

MR: Who would you to see?

SK: I would have loved to have seen Cannonball. Because a lot of those live shows, you just wish you were there, you know. Like you hear the crowd and you say yeah, I wish I was there watching that. And Jimi Hendrix. Yeah, you'd like to have been a part of that crowd. Yeah. I would say.

MR: What period of John Coltrane do you especially like?

SK: All of it.

MR: All of it.

SK: Yeah. I mean I like his early bebop stages, and that's the part about him — I like that he transitioned through so many different phases. And I know a lot of people like in the end, you know, he kind of went to outer space, you know, and it's kind of how he went out. He had like played through every phase in the music and he just took off. I mean I was — just yesterday I was listening to Trane and Bags, you know, with Milt Hinton and the vibe record.

MR: Yeah.

SK: Oh my God, man. The way he could play over a blues. And it's a lot of notes. Some people say he's like too notey or whatever, but if you can really catch some of that, it's like every note is right. It's perfect. And I do like some of the really hot stuff too, I have to say. Like the album "Transitions" is one of my favorites. "Meditations" is another one. But there's a lot to listen to with him.

MR: And who would you spend money on these days who is playing now?

SK: Who is playing now. Wow, see I haven't, that's a hard one.

MR: It would be hard for me too.

SK: Yeah, really.

MR: But you mentioned Kenny Garrett.

SK: Yes. Yeah. If he came to town I'd go see him. Yeah, definitely, yeah.

MR: Well wouldn't it be interesting to be able to take the funk feel that you usually work in, and try to combine it with more complex chord changes or something like that.

SK: Yes. I mean I try to do that when I write too as well, like for my stuff. I just do not make it a one chord thing, you know, where there's a bridge and there's a C section at the end, and then go back to somewhere else. Make it a little bit more interesting I guess, for the listener and for the musician.

MR: Well how do you write?

SK: A lot of it is us together in a group situation, where I'll have an idea for the melody and it's definitely a group. The past two situations have been. I haven't really come in with charts you know. But I'll have an idea of a tune and the way it's supposed to go. And this is another important thing about the whole situation is having people get it. You know, like having people who understand what you're talking about. Sometimes it can be a different language. Some people are like, "What do you mean?" And you're like uh. So it's good to have a chemistry with the people that you play with over the years, that sort of get what you're saying, you know, and you don't have to be super technical about it.

MR: Are most of the people in your band, are they — I hate to use the word — but are they college-trained musicians and schooled?

SK: Some. Just, well actually one. Amy, the keyboard player. She went to a classical school in North Carolina. Both Aaron and Nikki both went to Berklee but Aaron is self-taught as a bass player, and Nicky grew up like in churches so she was like — I say myself and Amy are the only really classically trained in the band.

MR: They probably all — it's probably hard to get everybody's schedule coordinated and say okay when are you free.

SK: Yeah. Especially now, everybody's doing something all the time.

MR: Sure. That's pretty much the life of a musician, you've got to take —

SK: Different, all different situations.

MR: Would there be opportunities in this area for you to play?

SK: You know I have kind of a network of people in Syracuse and in Albany, but I usually have to drag my Boston band back to the area. If there were opportunities, definitely I would.

MR: Any kind of music that you don't like? How would you know, you don't listen to it, right?

SK: I can say I don't listen to country. I won't say I don't like it, but I mean like I said, I have a really broad range of styles, but I don't listen to a lot of country I will say that.

MR: How about rap music.

SK: Oh I love it, love it, yeah. Definitely a big influence also.

MR: Because you're so rhythmic oriented.

SK: Yeah, yeah. And there's two things I think of when I play it too are drums and the rapper's passion. Like the way they flow, or the way their articulation on it.

MR: Drums and?

SK: Like hip hop, like rappers, emcees if you want to call it. Definitely rhythmic phrasing is what I definitely emphasize, more so than melodic.

MR: Well I've noticed that some of the melodies I've heard you play are like staccato with a capital S [scats]. You know they're very —

SK: Yeah. Short. That's what — me and Ryan joke about that too because you don't really have to be in tune because we like play it so fast that it sounds in tune. Like [brief horn] ah the reed's all dry, but you have to slow it down to really hear, was that in tune? But yeah. A lot of it is very percussive situations and fast.

MR: Do you ever growl into your horn.

SK: Sometimes, yeah. A lot of times when I'm way up in the high register I'll like to put my voice into it. It seems to just naturally happen too.

MR: Yeah. Right.

SK: Like you're just playing so hard and all of a sudden you're like ahhhh — into the horn.

MR: As a matter of fact, going back to that clip I was watching you on that tune, at one point you were popping out these [scats] I mean like way high.

SK: Oh yeah, like that.

MR: I mean do you have — people say well how do you play high like that? Are you doing overtones or do you just have special fingerings that you know sort of work.

SK: Fingerings, like high G — that's not going to work right now [scale] sorry, you may want to edit this part. [more horn] Yeah, all the regular fingerings usually is what I do. And then I'll do kind of I guess random stuff where it's kind of [scats] like in between notes and stuff. But not as much as like the overtone thing like you were talking about, it's mostly fingerings.

MR: Right, that was more of a classical thing to learn, of the Sigurd Rascher.

SK: Right. I haven't seen the stuff but I know it.

MR: Well some day I'm going to hear a clip of you playing with Soulive or your own band or whatever and I'm expecting to hear a quote from the Glazunov Concerto. Yes. Okay. So see if you can that in.

SK: Yes. Okay. I will, I will. Yeah, but that would be funny.

MR: Are you a mode thinker? Sometimes?

SK: Somewhat yeah, I would say a modal player, yeah. Not so much the exact correct thinking, but I guess that coincides with what we were talking about before, like playing outside the key sort of but in it. Does that make sense? Now what's a good example? But it would be, I think like that, yeah.

MR: Sometimes the jazz scales that I see I feel like boy am I out of date. I don't know what some of these things are.

SK: Yeah. Like not as much, but, I do a lot of listening, that's what I do, and the transcribing is also a good thing. I used to just sit and try and learn solos, you know, learn people's solos. I'm sure that's still a pretty good means of learning your instrument, learning different styles.

MR: Well if you had any advice for guys who might be in college, those people who want to be where you are, what would you say to them? Don't be taking my gigs?

SK: Yeah. Just keep doing what you're doing. Wow, get out as much as possible. Get out of the practice room, get out and play. Get over the hump of whatever, if you have stage fright or whatever, just try and find those situations and jump in. Like a lot of these what they call jam bands and jam festivals, go to festivals. Because a lot of it is open for people to sit in as well. A lot of these bands will see someone with a saxophone and will be like, "Come on" and you pretty much have opportunities to get out there and kind of explore and experiment with that scene you know. That would be my best advice, just to get out there and jump into it. That's what I did.

MR: Yeah. And living, I guess I asked this, but living in Rome, New York now, doesn't make that much difference for the kind of gigs you play because you have to travel anyway.

SK: Yeah. I mean I'll get in the car to go to New York or Boston, it's like a four hour trip or whatever. It hasn't really changed, yeah, as far as what I need to get to.

MR: Does this kind of music that you play fly in Europe?

SK: Oh yeah, yeah. And you know the one tour that I didn't do with Soulive was the European tour. I haven't had a chance to go to Europe yet, but I know that it's definitely very popular — more so than here I think. And Japan, again.

MR: That's been like that for years because even the guys that were playing in the forties and fifties, they used to say that, and now that they're older they say that in Japan they were treated like real artists or something.

SK: That's what I've been trying to say, yeah. They open the doors for you. They're like, "Here they come." You know what I mean? Yeah. It's something we haven't experienced as musicians, you're like royalty over there. It's just a higher level of playing.

MR: It's interesting, when things come from somewhere else we seem to value them more I guess.

SK: Yeah and so much of that is right here in front of them.

MR: Well do you want to close with a little bit of music?

SK: Sure.

MR: Oh, and by the way, when I was poking through the things on the internet, you sampled Cannonball and his — was it his "Mercy Mercy" thing? "Sometimes we're not prepared for adversity." [Cannonball's spoken introduction to "Mercy, Mercy, Mercy."]

SK: Yes. “You know sometimes we’re not prepared for adversity.” And then that song was a track I made on my keyboard synthesizer.

MR: Yeah. I got a kick out of that.

SK: I had to stick him in somewhere.

[plays]

SK: Do you have your horn?

MR: I do not have my horn.

[plays]

SK: I remember that was the first song you taught me. That and “Sack O Woe.”

MR: Thank you, Sam.